

Generative AI and the Improbable

Generative AI refers to systems that learn patterns from very large collections of data and then produce new material, such as text, images, sound or video, in response to a prompt. Diffusion models like Stable Diffusion, which was used for this assignment, learn to turn random noise into an image step by step, guided by a text description. They do not retrieve pictures from a database; they predict what an image matching my words is likely to look like, based on millions of captioned training images.

In creative fields, these tools are already used for concept art, mood boards, music production, design and film pre-visualization. Their main strength is speed of iteration: an artist can test dozens of compositions in minutes. Their weaknesses are just as real. Training data often includes artists' work used without consent, which raises ongoing questions about copyright, credit and creative labour.

My series, *Out of Office*, showed me both sides. I asked for a giant pocket watch behind a 1960s motel, a swimming pool full of letters, and mushrooms sprouting from the lawn. The model did not always obey: the watch shrank onto a postage stamp in the corner, and the letters flew out of the pool into the sky. This felt like failure at first, but it echoes the Dadaists' love of chance. The model's misreadings created juxtapositions I would never have planned, while the theme, the style and the decision about what to keep remained mine.

The work that inspires me most is Roope Rainisto's *Life In West America* (2023), a series of 500 images of a dreamlike American West inspired by early colour photography. Rainisto trained his own DreamBooth models, generated about 35,000 images, then refined his selections through inpainting and hand-editing. I was inspired by the faded mid-century Americana, quiet roadside scenes, and nostalgia for a place that never existed. What inspires me is that Rainisto does not hide the model's glitches; instead, he treats them as a new visual language. This made me understand that though models do not follow our steps to the fullest, it is better to embrace it and play on those changes.